

3.1.4 Hinduism

Students should be aware that Hinduism is one of the diverse religious traditions and beliefs in Great Britain today and that the main religious tradition in Great Britain is Christianity. This knowledge may be applied throughout the assessment of the specified content.

Students should study the beliefs, teachings and practices of Hinduism specified below and their basis in Hindu sources of wisdom and authority. They should be able to refer to scripture and/or sacred texts where appropriate. Some texts are prescribed for study in the content set out below and questions may be set on them. Students may refer to any relevant text in their answers and AQA will publish a list of appropriate texts as part of the supporting material for this specification. These additional texts will not be required for study, alternatives may be used, and questions will not be set on them.

Students should study the influence of the beliefs, teachings and practices studied on individuals, communities and societies.

Common and divergent views within Hinduism in the way beliefs and teachings are understood and expressed should be included throughout. Students may refer to a range of different Hindu perspectives in their answers, including Shaivism and Vaishnavism. They must study the specific differences identified below.

3.1.4.1 Beliefs and teachings

Ideas about the nature of God and existence

- Brahman: different Hindu understandings of brahman; ultimate reality as divine consciousness (nirguna) and manifestation of God in form (saguna); spiritual worlds.
- Different understandings of the three features of the divine:
 - everywhere, as non-personal (brahman)
 - within the heart
 - beyond, as a personal loving God
 - Brihadaranyaka Upanishad 391.
- How the divine presents:
 - the Tri-murti: Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva
 - male and female deities, including Ganesha, Lakshmi, Hanuman, Saraswati
 - the concept of avatara, including Krishna, Rama.
- Matter (prakriti); the three qualities (tri-guna); illusion (maya); cosmology (Rig Veda 10.129.6-7); the cycle of four ages; many worlds and their diverse inhabitants.

Beliefs about the nature of human life

- The concept of atman, as individual, eternal inner self, distinct from material mind and body.
- Cycle of birth and death: samsara; moral action and reaction: the law of karma; types of liberation: moksha.
- Individual free will and responses to suffering; knowledge and ignorance.
- Personal virtues including ahimsa, respect, empathy, mind/sense control, humility, love.
- The four aims of human life: dharma, artha, kama, moksha.
- The meaning of dharma; sanatana dharma; varnashrama dharma.

3.1.4.2 Practices

Worship and festivals

- Places of worship and their importance: home; temple; outdoors (such as shrines); the space of the heart
- Different forms of worship/meditation and their significance: havan, puja, arati, darshan, bhajan/kirtan, japa/mantra; key differences in worship in Shaivism and Vaishnavism and different Hindu views about the importance of worship.
- Focuses of worship and representations of the divine and their importance:
 - one God (personal or non-personal)
 - the many deities, guru and other elders
 - holy land, hills and rivers
 - sacred plants and animals
 - the murti as a representation of God.
- Sacred festivals and their importance for Hindus in Great Britain today, including the origins and meaning of:
 - Diwali
 - Holi.

Lifestyle

- The four paths towards yoga (union with the divine), their differences and their importance:
 - action (karma yoga)
 - knowledge (jnana yoga)
 - meditation (astanga yoga)
 - devotion (bhakti yoga).
- Pilgrimage:
 - the role of pilgrimage
 - practices and purposes
 - sacred sites, including Varanasi
 - Kumbh Mela.
- The work and significance of:
 - Hindu environmental projects including 'cow protection' and their significance.
 - Charities that promote well-being, social inclusion and women's rights.